

Woodland, Desert, and Grassland



MOST OF AUSTRALIA HAS a dry climate. Vast areas in the middle of the continent are covered by hot desert, grassland, and scrubland, called the bush or outback. Some birds, such as chats, grasswrens, parrots, and pigeons, manage to find enough seeds and fruits to survive there, although they have to fly long distances to find water. Birds of prey can also live here by feeding on the many desert reptiles and small marsupials.

In the southeast and southwest of Australia are woodlands where a variety of eucalyptus trees grow. Here the climate is generally cooler and wetter. Marshes sometimes form during the rainy season, providing food and nesting places for ibises, pelicans, black swans, and ducks. Honeyeaters and lorikeets feed on the nectar and pollen in the eucalyptus trees and in flowering shrubs, such as grevilleas and banksias. As they feed, the birds help pollinate the flowers and spread their seeds. Birds that feed on insects also find a rich supply of food on eucalyptus trees.



Sharp, pointed bill for stabbing reptiles, such as this snake.

Laughing kookaburra
(*Dacelo novaeguineae*)
Length: 1 ft 4 in (42 cm)

Laughing kookaburra

This giant member of the kingfisher family is named after its loud hooting and chuckling call. This warns other birds to keep out of its territory. Several birds may join in the laughter, usually in the early morning or late afternoon. It sometimes comes to town and city gardens to eat the food that people leave out for it, and has also been known to raid goldfish ponds.

Western spinebill

The western spinebill uses its needle-thin, curved bill to probe for nectar in flowers. Its long bill can reach inside tube-shaped flowers or push into stiff, brushlike flowers, such as banksias. It sometimes hovers in front of flowers to drink the nectar, soaking it up with a brush at the tip of its tongue.

Western spinebill
(*Acanthorhynchus superciliosus*)
Length: 6 in (15.5 cm)

A western spinebill feeds on nectar from the flowers of a red gum, which is a kind of eucalyptus.



A male brown honeyeater feeds on a banksia flower. As honeyeaters feed, they help pollinate flowers.

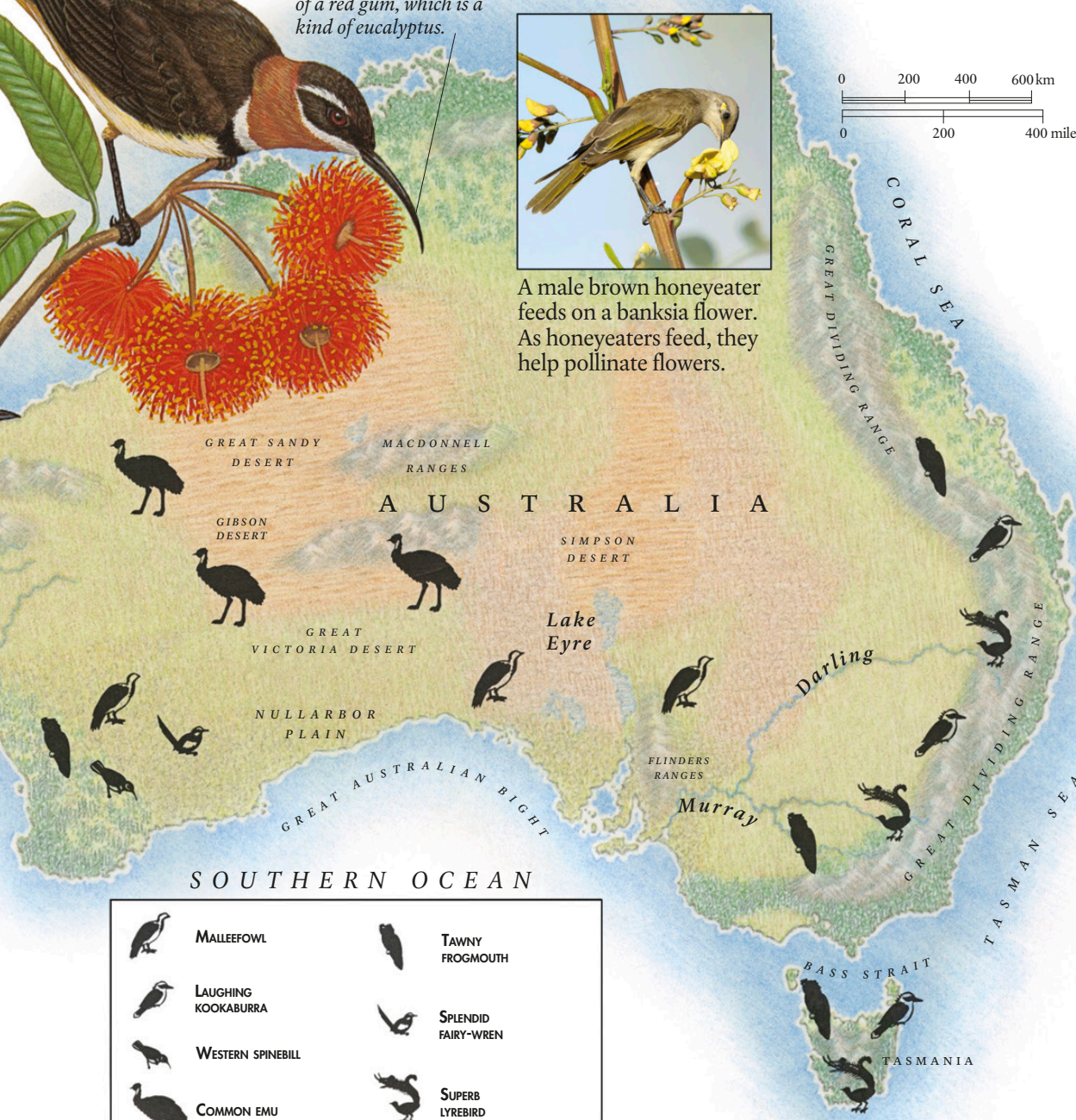
Splendid fairy-wren
(*Malurus splendens*)
Length: 5 in (13.5 cm)

This bird often cocks its tail when perched on a branch.

Males have shiny, bright blue feathers in the breeding season. Females are much duller in color all year.

Splendid fairy-wren

Pairs of splendid, or banded, fairy-wrens nest in small groups, with extra birds helping feed and defend the young. The helpers may be young birds that have not yet left their parents and started to fend for themselves. They help their younger brothers and sisters survive.



	MALLEEFOWL		TAWNY FROGMOUTH
	LAUGHING KOOKABURRA		SPLendid FAIRY-WREN
	WESTERN SPINEBILL		SUPERB LYREBIRD
	COMMON EMU		